There are three outdoor camps during the course of training; Camp Greenhorn in the second term, Camp Rover in the fourth and Camp Torna/Trishul in the sixth. The entire course goes out for four to six days, to practise the practical aspects of military training. Each of these culminates in an endurance run back to the Academy while navigating through pre-set waypoints. All the camps are also inter-squadron competitions with the endurance run, or 'Josh Run' as it is popularly known, carrying the maximum marks. We had done well in all the smaller competitions during Camp Greenhorn, coming first in tent pitching, night navigation, etc. Now, only the Josh Run, an endurance run of 10 miles (16 km) with full kit, stood between us and the first position. Alas, disaster struck. Somewhere en route we read the map wrong and got lost, losing valuable time. By the time we regained our bearings, the other squadrons had overtaken us. We were devastated. Perhaps we had become overconfident, having breezed through the night navigation exercise. Lesson learnt. In Camp Rover two terms later, we won all the competitions, including the Josh Run, and brought home the trophy. In the fifth term, along with all the routine training, we also branch out for our respective service training—Army, Navy or Air Force. The Navy guys learn sailing at the picturesque Peacock Bay; the Air Force guys learn gliding and take to the skies. The Army guys are taken to the nearest hillock and learn how to dig trenches and sleep in them. I say this not out of any rancour, but to bring out that it leads to an attitudinal change. Just because of this trifurcation, the same cadets who used to lead the pack were floundering in the sixth-term Josh Run. It was bewildering for me that I was now cajoling some of these Navy and Air Force CMs, even carrying their rifles or backpacks. Attitude is everything and decides the outcome even before you start.

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